



Working with difference: Cognitive schemas, ethical cosmopolitanism and negotiating cultural diversity

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Abstract

This article empirically explores the types and limits of ethical varieties of cosmopolitan openness by analysing in-depth interviews with a sample of professionals and volunteers ($N = 20$) in culturally heterogeneous workplaces that are characterised by interpersonal interactions requiring intercultural competencies. It analyses the way people relax and harden the borders of openness around people, objects and practices they see as unfamiliar and different. Within the context of two primary schemes for deliberating the principles and schemas for acting in ways that are open to valuing difference, the article finds that the interviewees use flexible and contextually shifting categorisations of otherness and sameness that serve apparently conflicting agendas of ethical openness, self-protection, instrumentalism and parochialism. Exploring the schemas associated with these forms of everyday ethical understandings, the results show their cosmopolitan ethical practice to be performative and contextual, entangled with a variety of potentially conflicting schemas of evaluation and judgement.

Keywords

Cognitive schemas, cosmopolitanism, cultural diversity, ethical cosmopolitanism

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Reconceiving cosmopolitanism

Over the past few decades, an important shift has taken place which has changed understandings of what cosmopolitanism entails and also what it offers the social sciences. Cosmopolitanism has implications for understanding not just the flows and mobilities associated with post-national outlooks and formations, but the way cultural pluralism and diversity are managed and integrated in diverse social settings. The origins of the cosmopolitan concept posit the cosmopolitan individual as a pure or selfless 'citizen of the world' (Kant, 1970 [1795]; Inglis, 2012). However, more recently this philosophical approach to cosmopolitanism research was critically extended via explorations of the messy, conflicting and often unpredictable processes in response to the mobility of people and things (Phillips and Smith, 2008; Roudometof, 2012; Savage et al., 2005; Skrbiš and Woodward, 2007). One dimension of this shift has been towards empirical studies of 'getting along' in culturally diverse settings, focusing on concepts such as hospitality, openness and conviviality (Jones et al., 2015; Lobo, 2014, 2016; Noble, 2013; Plage et al., 2017). A proposition implicit within contemporary cosmopolitan research is that for people navigating a world characterised by diversity and multiple strangerhoods (Amin, 2013; Rumford, 2013) openness towards and knowledge of the cultural Other should not be conceived exclusively as an ethical disposition. Indeed, it is a skill instrumental not just for getting along across racial and ethnic racial boundaries, but for success, status, and the translation of forms of capital (Molz, 2012; Peterson and Kern, 1996; Skeggs, 2004; Skrbiš and Woodward, 2011). Therefore, while the tag 'cosmopolitan' originally described a selfless and transparent disposition of openness to difference, research attention has also been directed towards symbolically or culturally powerful groups whose cosmopolitanism is largely consumptive, status-oriented and instrumentalist (Bookman, 2013; Elliott and Urry, 2010; Skrbiš and Woodward, 2007), and whose practices may even reproduce power hierarchies (Hage, 1997; Skeggs, 2004). The result of this pattern of research effort is that we possess insights about cosmopolitanism as a type of cultural and symbolic capital which is performatively accomplished, but relatively little empirical detail about forms of 'actually existing' (Robbins, 1998) ethical openness to difference, despite this dimension acknowledged to be a signature element of cosmopolitan reflexivity and imagination (Delanty, 2009).

Problematising this turn within the field, we argue for a need to identify the channels through which everyday forms of ethical openness originate, its limits and contexts, and how it is discursively enacted. To reveal the complexities and contradictions of narrative and discursive frames that people draw upon to make sense of their perceived moral commitments to others, we decided to analyse interviews with people working and volunteering in areas of transcultural and transnational helping. We reasoned that these individuals were more likely than the wider population to embody strong ethical cosmopolitan sensibilities, and analysing their discursive strategies would thereby enable us to understand the character of expressions of ethical cosmopolitanism. While our research presents discussions of professional practices of managing integration, welfare and social security services related to health and employment, the interview participants were also asked a variety of semi-structured and open-ended questions to accumulate information about their responses to difference in a variety of contexts, including humanitarian

occupations, embodied encounters, international travel and multicultural consumption. By taking this approach, we return to the original Kantian emphasis on ethical forms of cosmopolitanism, inductively and critically exploring the current status of Kant's pure and selfless 'citizen of the world' to develop an holistic working understanding of the status and limits of ethical cosmopolitan practice and how it works when professional obligations and practices intersect with personal views and experiences.

Actually existing ethical cosmopolitanism: Dilemmas and conflicts

Appiah (2006: xv) clarifies that the cosmopolitan ethic is defined by acknowledgement of obligations to others beyond ties of citizenship or kin, and a recognition of the value of particular human lives, in all their diversity and difference. One significant obstacle in the task of empirically defining ethical cosmopolitanism is that the interrelationships between ethical and status-oriented forms of cosmopolitan social action are inadequately specified, and indeed rarely acknowledged in the literature in terms of motives for ethical action. As engagements with the cultural Other moved beyond the realm of imagination and into everyday routine (Amin, 2013; Dromi, 2012; Valentine, 2008), and as researchers began to investigate forms of actually existing cosmopolitanism (Lamont and Aksartova, 2002; Robbins, 1998; Skrbish and Woodward, 2007), the idea of the selfless global citizen became subject to empirical critique (Calhoun, 2002; Hage, 1997; hooks, 1992; Woodward et al., 2008). In fact, there is recognition that globalisation entailed the emergence of political policies, business imperatives, mobility practices and cultural discourses that made it necessary to demonstrate flexibility in the face of boundaries between the global, the national and the self in the quest for cultural competence and economic colonisation (Beck, 2000, 2002). As one example of this, research on the concept of the cultural omnivore suggested that under conditions of globalisation, people seek to acquire forms of moral, cultural and economic capital by showing a capacity to code-switch and interact with the symbols, cultural forms and practices of different cultures (Peterson and Kern, 1996). Yet, how might these cultural repertoires relate to ethical practices? The centrepiece of the cosmopolitan project, its ethical component which promises a critical rehabilitation of obligations and hospitality in a global context (Delanty, 2009), is under-researched in terms of empirical and everyday expressions and in particular how it becomes entangled with other motives for social action.

The possibility of unexpected or perverse outcomes arising at the intersection of instrumental and ethical action not only applies to business people or cultural elites, but can also point to potential contradictions in seemingly selfless cosmopolitan behaviours. These diverse and sometimes contradictory threads – which suggest the idea that seemingly cosmopolitan practices can have un-cosmopolitan outcomes – are also largely missing from research in the area, though there are pointers from research in associated fields that suggest their relevance. As Peterson and Kern argued in their classical conception of the taste omnivore (1996: 906), 'while snobbish exclusion was an effective marker of status in a relatively homogeneous and circumscribed WASP-ish world that could enforce its dominance over all others by force if necessary, omnivorous inclusion

seems better adapted to an increasingly global world managed by those who make their way, in part, by showing respect for the cultural expressions of others'. This resonates with Warde et al.'s (1999) delineation of the potential contradictions associated with the position of the cultural omnivore as balancing apparent inclusivity and cultural openness within frameworks of refinement and cultural superiority via the skilful application of styles and genres that are implicitly, rather than explicitly, hierarchicalised. Indeed, more generally, Becker (1974: 1083) noted that 'apparent "charitable" behaviour can also be motivated by a desire to avoid the scorn of others or to receive social acclaim'. Similarly, in his research on collective action, Olson (1965: 60) has made the point that 'people are sometimes motivated [to be open to cultural difference] by a desire to win prestige, respect, friendship, and other social and psychological objectives'. One particularly rich example illustrating these dilemmas is found in practices of international volunteering, increasingly afforded by factors such as workforce flexibilisation, relative affluence that affords mobility, and the enterprising culture of neoliberalism (Vrasti and Montsion, 2014). Sometimes, such cosmopolitan practice combines ethical values with the pursuit of social capital in the form of credentialism and demonstrated performance of global qualifications and workplace experience (Jones, 2011).

Debates have recently intensified around these questions, with critical scholarship pointing out the stark differences in subjective and structural interpretations of such seemingly humanitarian practices. In the case of volunteering abroad, for example, Vrasti and Montsion (2014) admit that this is often animated subjectively by 'cosmopolitan impulses of care, compassion and even brotherly love', but that seen in a governmentality context it becomes a set of techniques for equipping and disciplining 'spaces, communities and identities as favourable junctions in the global flow of capital' (Vrasti and Montsion, 2014: 339). And, as summarised by Snee (2013: 158), within gap year narratives which rest on moral notions of transnational helping and fostering cosmopolitan experiences, a tension exists where structural and historical legacies of inequality and difference are in fact often reproduced by the volunteers themselves. Cosmopolitanism is, according to such a position, both a product of and tool for mobilising the affective and instrumental requirements of neoliberal global capitalism. With this in mind, we must remain open to the possibility that seemingly ethical cosmopolitan behaviours are partially directed by instrumental and status-oriented goals, rather than necessarily being selfless or altruistic. Importantly, therefore, a crucial conceptual task is to draw a stronger line in distinguishing between superficial, self-interested and ethical forms of cosmopolitan openness and ethical action (Plage et al., 2017).

Being aware of this potential for entanglement of self-interested and altruistic agendas, we developed an operational definition and methodological approach to distinguish between ethical and self-interested forms of cosmopolitanism. Central to this task were sociological theories of civil society that utilise ideas about cultural value and classification, and the symbolic boundaries of purity and pollution (Douglas, 2003 [1966]). These theories have been recognised before in some discussions of cosmopolitanism (Alexander, 2013; Turner, 2012), and as Seidman has recently reminded us, 'border politics are at the heart of the sociology of the Other' (Seidman, 2013: 6). More particularly, utilising theories about bordering, boundaries (Douglas, 2003 [1966]) and cognitive sociology (Zerubavel, 1996, 2009), we contend that negative cognitive

categorisations of difference involve constructing symbolic (cognitive) boundaries and borders between citizens of the host country and minority cultural groups, but importantly, at the same time, that the flexibility of these boundaries gives opportunities to transcend restrictive interactions with diversities. Ethical cosmopolitanism, which in theory differs from self-focused openness by its concrete contribution towards humanistic notions of a fair and egalitarian world, must exist as a reflexive capacity to challenge negative categories of belonging and identity that inform everyday relations with difference. Ethical cosmopolitan action renders symbolic boundaries and borders porous and so symbolically flattens cultural hierarchies. This discursive (and ultimately cognitive) skill of reconstructing difference through the lens of connection and commonality, rather than absolute and irreconcilable difference, defines ethical cosmopolitan sociality. Drawing upon concepts of discourse analysis (Jørgensen and Phillips, 2002) and observing the narrative frames and vocabularies people utilise to talk about cultural difference enable us to observe this process: to empirically explore how, when and to what extent positive re-categorisations of difference are achieved. With this as our point of departure, we will proceed to explore whether people who have chosen work that requires cultural sensitivity and competence demonstrate such boundary work and deeper, more ethical forms of cosmopolitan openness. Furthermore, we ask whether this is a workplace performance required in the globalised marketplace, or if people in professions with higher exposure to cultural diversity develop, experience and express a deep and ethical commitment to humanitarian values.

Methodology

This article draws on a large body of qualitative data consisting of focus groups and semi-structured interviews with 200 participants collected for a study of cosmopolitan encounters in Australia. The in-depth interviews analysed for the current article comprise a sub-sample purposively selected from the larger project sample, and provides insight into the narrated and socially contextualised openness practices of 20 individuals ranging from 22 to 79 years of age from diverse socio-economic backgrounds. The primary criterion for drawing our sample was that the interviewee must be either a volunteer with a community organisation that services people from diverse ethnic and racial backgrounds, or alternatively a professional who reported that they routinely encountered and engaged with ethnically or racially different people as part of their everyday work. In this context, our in-depth, semi-structured interviews allowed each person the time to present their story in great detail, in a private interview setting where it was felt to be less intimidating to reveal potentially inconsistent or unfavourable aspects of self (Pugh, 2014). Notably, 18 out of the 20 interviewees who reported regular dealings with diverse publics, and identified that the recipients of their services are ethnically and culturally diverse – such as teachers, nurses, social or aged-care workers – were women. Indeed, this does not surprise us, seeing that multiple researchers of cosmopolitanism and related fields have suggested women are more likely to embody differently founded varieties of cosmopolitanism than their male counterparts (Høy-Petersen et al., 2016; Nava, 2007; Vieten, 2012) and that they are more likely to work in these person-centred, helping professions. This gendered feature of the sample is in itself crucial and we consider the implications

of it later in the article. However, it also means that we have limited ability to comparatively explore gender differences in the practices of ethical openness in these settings.

The research is directed by a commitment to studying the way meaning is constructed and contextually negotiated, including through the filter of the research interview. To analytically separate ethical cosmopolitanism from other forms and reveal the complexities and internal contradictions of acting in ethically cosmopolitan ways, we follow guidelines that suggest scrutinising the interview narrative and looking for divergent expressions and findings within it (Pugh, 2014). Using NVivo software, and to ensure that our subjective perceptions and theoretical interests had minimal impact on how we organised these data, interview transcripts were subjected to an initial stage of inductive open-coding (Corbin and Strauss, 1990). In a second stage of focused coding, we then proceeded to single out and explore further the primary pattern of interest, namely focusing on two different vocabularies our interviewees use to frame cultural difference that we identified in the open-coding stage.

Inspired by discourse analysis (Jørgensen and Phillips, 2002) and drawing upon a tradition of cognitive sociology (Cerulo, 2001; DiMaggio, 1997; Vaisey, 2009; Zerubavel, 1996, 2009) devoted to the social and cultural structures and consequences of human cognition, we show that the first of these vocabularies, containing cues such as ‘mother’, ‘family’, ‘home’, or referring to universal aspects of humanity including shared human needs and emotions, reveals that a visceral-based schema is used to frame interviewees’ engagements with cultural difference. Our use of the term visceral is principally adopted from the work of Nava (2007), and refers to understandings of difference which emerge from feelings which are formed sometimes in embodied encounters, but other times the work of perceptions and emotional registers in understanding difference. In Nava’s terms, these constitute forms of ‘everyday cosmopolitanism and the socio-emotional aspects of *anti-racism*’ (2002: 89). The second narrative scheme, which draws on technical, legalistic and abstract meaning frames, often referring to political, economic, legal and governmental discourses related to matters of immigration, multiculturalism and Otherness, indicates when interview participants are employing knowledge-based cognitive strategies to manage their engagements with difference (see Høy-Petersen et al., 2016). Rather than identifying cross-cultural human similarities, defining ethical cosmopolitan openness and its limits centres on reflexive reasoning and the ability to knit together pieces of information drawn from various discourses in order to construct the Other as being either ‘good’ or ‘bad’, ‘worthy’ or ‘unworthy’, regardless of being similar or different. With this in mind, we will commence our findings section by outlining narrative examples that help explore how ethical cosmopolitanism is accomplished – both in and outside the workplace. We will then proceed to outline situations in which ethical cosmopolitan categorisations become challenged and suspended as social actors pursue conflicting objectives, move through different social settings, and engage in a diversity of practices that shape their framings of cultural difference.

Ethical cosmopolitanism and visceral schemas

Our qualitative findings reveal the use of two major schemas for managing cultural difference: one we characterise as a visceral-based schema, and the other as a knowledge-based

schema. We find them to be master categories from which people draw more specific frames of reasoning about their ethical obligations to others. Turning first to the visceral component for managing difference, interviewees reported that having the bodies and faces of diverse cultural groups in relatively close proximity prompted a temporary neutralisation of culturally predefined perceptions of difference founded in emotional responsiveness to the human face (Levinas, 1991). Indeed, as narrated by a medical student in her mid-twenties, 'having people from different cultures living around you as your neighbours or that you interact with at the shops and stuff breaks down that thing of "oh, they're so scary"'. Bearing a similar message, an older male social worker who had developed meaningful friendships with his neighbours of Italian and Middle Eastern descent suggested 'taking time to get to know your neighbours' as the root of functional multiculturalism. Lastly, for a woman who volunteered helping culturally diverse children in foster care, it was clear that 'people become more open-minded when they see a lot of different people'. As she explains in the following quote, she understood that her experience in encounters with indigenous people at school had challenged the parochialism instilled in her by her father:

My father was against all races and I grew up thinking that's the way it's supposed to be. When I got older I started to become friends with some indigenous girls at school and I thought I don't know what he's talking about. I had a fear of indigenous people because it was put into me to think they were bad. But as I became friends with people from different cultures I just had more of an understanding that we might have different views, but everyone's pretty much the same.

In her narrative, this woman implies that face-to-face cultural encounters inspired her to substitute fear of 'bad' indigenous people with humanistic notions of 'sameness' and 'friendship'. As we suggested above, this reflexive and viscerally founded questioning of negative categorisations of difference catalysed by proximity to 'face' can be framed through the work of Levinas. According to Levinas's (1991) concept of 'face-ethics', the human face can reveal, through perception, inter-human vulnerabilities to its viewer – installing a felt responsibility to respond empathically to the Other. Recognising a shared humanity and spectrum of human emotions in the face of the Other prompts a positive judgement of them as being fundamentally similar to oneself, and thus non-threatening to one's physical and moral integrity. This denotes a flattening of hierarchies of cultural value as well as a relaxation of protective boundaries and borders. Notably, Levinas's 'ethics of face' has affinities with Gilligan's (1982) theory that women are socialised to practise an 'ethics of care'. And, while we lack the gender balance in our sample necessary to support this claim empirically, it may be that women have a stronger inclination to draw on cognitive frames related to embodiment and viscosity in their practice of ethical cosmopolitanism. Indeed, one interviewee stated to us that 'women are a bit more open to change' and more 'susceptible' to casual chats with people from other cultures. Furthermore, according to Nava (2007), women's experience of oppression and their capacity to relate emotionally to others may make them better able to empathise with the Other. Whilst we acknowledge such a general statement requires further exploration, expanding this argument beyond gender relations, we found support in our interview data for the idea that social marginalisation may make people more empathic to the

experiences of Others. This was exemplified by a woman in her thirties, a teacher of primary school students, who described her experience of growing up in poverty as an important influence on her aspirations to help all people regardless of their ethnic origin:

It seems to me that the people who struggle the most are the people who have had diversity in their life. We were sent to public school and I feel that's made me a better person. The people that have less help other people who have less, whereas I've heard some of the most ridiculous things from people who are basically professionals, and anybody who is ethnically different, or religiously different, physically different, they'll just neglect.

The ethically cosmopolitan ability to empathise with the Other on the basis of perceived shared experience was imagined by some of our interviewees as a skill associated with people who have the capacity to get along with others due to their 'down-to-earth' social background and diverse upbringing (see also Lamont and Aksartova, 2002). Even so, most of our interviewees demonstrated an ability to juggle both visceral and knowledge-based repertoires for working with and negotiating difference.

Ethical cosmopolitanism and knowledge-based schemas

Those who most prominently relied on visceral schemas and performed ethical cosmopolitan openness by constructing categories of sameness would occasionally use knowledge-based forms of reasoning to understand unfamiliar cultures and negotiate their anxieties about them. This would include, for example, references to the ancient or recent histories of cultural and ethnic groups; knowledge of the content and meanings of cultural norms and traditions; or even ethical pointers applicable to transcultural engagements picked up from political discourse, social norms of solidarity and egalitarianism, traditions of moral philosophy, or understandings about universal human rights. Most central to the knowledge-based repertoire for ethical openness was the ability to practise a culturally relativist perspective. This skill was expertly demonstrated by a young teacher, who, in the following quote, delineates her efforts to counteract her student's negative visceral disgust responses to other cultural traditions:

Some kids say 'oh Asians, *YUCK!* All they do is eat dogs.' I'll say 'well, we're the selfish ones because we are picky with what animals we eat'. I like to make them think about it in another way: 'We are lucky here because we can grow a cow out in a paddock and eat it. But there are people who live with the whole population of Australia in one camp so they've got to eat everything.' Afterwards, once you take that away from a racial comment they go, 'oh, right'. Maybe they'll think differently about saying that again.

As this woman explains, people can learn to question and apply knowledge-based reasoning strategies to counter their own potentially negative feelings towards cultural difference. This association between learning and intellectually inspired forms of openness was explicitly stated by a woman who when asked about the source of her openness towards different cultures explained that 'learning more about history, learning more knowledge about everything opened my eyes up'. Another female working in community service

similarly replied that her education had helped her to practise ethical forms of openness regardless of her parochial fears by enabling her to see 'both sides of the story'. In fact, this link between learning and openness was one she observed throughout her family:

I think my mum is quite open-minded and my dad he's one of those people who will make derogatory jokes and that could be that my mum she's a lawyer and dad left school at 16 and didn't have that education. So I think education definitely has a lot to do with it and again, my grandparents, some of the things they say makes me cringe. I'm like 'that's not politically correct and it's very narrow-minded and very not listening to the other sides' and again, I think that's to do with education. I've been so fortunate in that I have been given the opportunity to see the importance of seeing both sides of the story.

Regardless of statements such as this, we question the notion that people who frame the Other via knowledge-based reasoning strategies rather than visceral schemas are somehow better or more complete cosmopolitans. Their aspirations to achieve ethically cosmopolitan goals may be the same, even if differences in their personal and social backgrounds lead them to approach this objective using divergent strategies. While the small size of our sample makes us hesitant to generalise, socio-economic status emerged in our findings as a core determinant of people's approach to doing ethical cosmopolitanism, causing them to draw more heavily on one of the two cognitive schemas. For example, a person who has grown up or resides in a less privileged neighbourhood – perhaps an unskilled labourer – is likely to have more frequent encounters and contact with immigrants, cultural and ethnic diversities who are often underprivileged, as well as exposure to some of the same hardships and experiences. Indeed, as was suggested in Lamont and Aksartova's (2002) empirical explorations of how cosmopolitanism is done by the working class, working class people are likely to have first hand experience and everyday familiarity with diverse cultural and ethnic people, as well as to develop competencies in such face-to-face encounters. For people who grow up in more affluent neighbourhoods, on the other hand, diversity and culture is commonly less of a familiar tangible and experiential reality, and more an abstract intellectual endeavour, dealt with in politics, cultural discourses and education. With this social and experiential distance, it seems social interaction with Otherness can be emotionally and cognitively demanding. For more affluent individuals, then, their ethical cosmopolitan aspirations are more likely to be expressed in ways familiar within their habitus; the knowledge-based schema, rhetoric and argumentation for human rights and concerning immigration policies, and helping behaviours that require some knowledge of legal and structural issues. In our interview data, some highly educated individuals would for example profess to be less inclined, comfortable or competent to engage in visceral or proximal bonding with others. In one instance, a retired lawyer who now practises *pro bono* told us that 'it's easy to make friends with people with whom you have common ground. It's not that I avoid Aboriginal people, It's just that, where do you start?' Regardless of being unable to feel connected with the Other, her ability and willingness to speak up for cultural groups in legal matters combined with a belief about an 'expectation of behaviour to put something back into society' would allow bridging of cultural differences in particular contexts, and enable her to challenge symbolic and perhaps also structural boundaries and borders. In a perfectly cosmopolitan society, cultural and ethnic Others would be included in everyday

life, through social contact and sharing of experiences, as well as intellectually through interest in and knowledge of their histories, cultural traditions, effective inclusive rhetoric and assistance to challenge parochial views and structural boundaries within the host country. There are of course people proficient in both forms of ethical cosmopolitanism, but as suggested by our data, they are likely to be few and far between. What we observe is that our assumed ethically cosmopolitan individuals are not perfect in their practice. And, assuming that emotions and knowledge can also work against ethical cosmopolitan action, what happens when objectives emerge that conflict with the impetus to be open?

Challenges to ethical cosmopolitanism: Perceived threats to self and self-interest

Our findings indicated that in order to address multiple social and political demands associated with global complexity, people must balance multiple conflicting cosmopolitan and parochial, ethical and self-interested practices. While we anticipated our assumed 'archetypical' ethical cosmopolitans would prove somewhat robust in face of such challenges, we instead found them to temporarily suspend their repertoires of ethical openness to manage experiences of various perceived types of threat, as well as embrace opportunities for pleasure and cultural capital accumulation associated with multicultural Australia and the globalised world more generally. The first of these major threats to ethical cosmopolitan openness – namely the experience of having one's personal safety or property threatened – is understood as emerging from the parameters of the cosmopolitan encounter itself. As we have suggested, practising ethical cosmopolitanism differs distinctly from more superficial and instrumentalist forms of cosmopolitan engagements in that it involves a conscious relaxing of the boundaries and borders that protect the self, as well as a crossing of personal comfort zones. Ironically, then, by rendering the self open and vulnerable, ethical cosmopolitan practice inevitably generates some un-cosmopolitan anxieties. Put simply, practices of ethical cosmopolitanism are convoluted, and commonly interrupted or challenged by conflicting objectives of self-protection. One example of this was presented to us by a nurse who, like all of our interviewees, was assumed to embody a high degree of cultural sensitivity and ethically cosmopolitan skills. But, while this woman described herself as a 'very friendly' and 'non-suspicious person' who valued deeper engagements with other cultures on her travels, discussing her meeting a manicurist in Bali led her to conclude that there is always 'love and hate in anybody's relationship':

I do have a degree of suspicion. I was in Bali once and this young girl used to come up to me and say 'come on, I'll do your nails, I'll do your nails!' I was there for about a week, and I thought okay. She took me behind this group of shops and I thought, whoah, we're going a little bit too far out of the tourist area. So, I was watching around ... I always believe in just that little bit of space at the top of my head to say, you might be a very nice person, but you might be planning on sending me off to Southeast Asia as a sex slave or something.

Having described how in the process of extending openness and trust to a Balinese stranger, she reaches the limits of her ethical cosmopolitanism, we notice a change taking place in her narrative framings of difference. Recalling the encounter, she suddenly

reverts to prejudiced discourses, racist stereotyping, and categories of 'dirt', hardening her boundaries and borders in the name of self-protection. A similar example was presented to us by another woman, who used her knowledge of immigration policies to 'stick up for' immigrants, and who also demonstrated a viscerally founded recognition that people from different cultures 'might have learnt things differently, we might talk differently, we might dress differently, but we're all the same inside'. Even so, after recollecting the sense of embodied threat and harassment she once felt in encounters with the Italian migrant population of Sydney, her attempt at discursively neutralising perceived difference and danger is circumscribed by the conflicting objectives of self-protection. As this happens, she commences a depersonalised discussion of the limits of Australia's ability to accommodate immigrants:

Facilitator: You suggested it wouldn't worry you so much if there were large number of migrant groups, right? Can it just be endless numbers?

Interviewee: That's really interesting [pause]. Because I would hate for it to be a huge majority of people. I have bad memories from Newtown which became little Italy in those days and those men were pretty disgusting because I was a well-endowed young girl. I think it's a good idea to intersperse them around country towns, and that they have to be taught English. We have a responsibility to help but how far does that helping go? I don't know how many Australia can cope with. Infrastructure can't happen overnight.

Importantly, however, the temporary cognitive distancing from the Other narrated in these examples is not a consistent thread in our interviews. Instead, whilst acknowledging problematic zones and tensions around difference and Otherness, interviewees commonly rationalise the meaning of such differences by dwelling on positive features of diversity. Drawing on the work of Valentine (2008), we suggest that people do this because dominant western discourses have associated civility and etiquette with notions of moral and aesthetic refinement, prompting individuals to act out mundane and ritualised egalitarian codes of etiquette in public spaces regardless of their privately held views and values. She writes, and our findings support this view, that 'this urban etiquette does not equate with an ethics of care and mutual respect for difference' (Valentine, 2008: 329). And, although we first considered it difficult to distinguish between ethical openness which entails cognitively flattening hierarchies of cultural value and 'empty' variations inspired by instrumentalist objectives, most interviewees were explicit about whether the practices of openness recounted in their narratives were ethically underpinned or not. Among our examples of this was a female medical student who volunteered at a mobile soup kitchen. In cases where she was unable to cognitively neutralise perceptions of cultural difference and dirt, and where her openness did not flow from a position of perceived sameness or worth, she would revert to familiar schemas to follow in order to maintain an appropriate egalitarian representation of self:

I do judge people, though, in my head. Maybe they wouldn't realise cause I still try and treat them nicely – like at the soup kitchen there was a brother and his sister who came from a

Muslim study group. She was wearing a headscarf and everything. Even though it's probably judgemental, I was wondering if she's allowed to talk to boys the way her brother was talking to me. I still wouldn't treat him rudely, but I have my little opinions and thoughts going on.

In addition to perceived threats to one's moral and physical integrity, the capacity to perform ethical cosmopolitanism expressed by our interviewees was also challenged by hedonistic and self-interested objectives associated with practices of consumption and travel. In accordance with our understanding of ethical cosmopolitanism, multicultural consumption and international travel should be framed in narratives as a means to reconfigure borders between Other and self. Surprisingly, then, the opposite was often the case. A typical example of this was presented by a woman employed in indigenous dialysis-based nursing, who explained trips abroad as a means to get a sense of the exotic and 'be taken away from the routine of everyday life' where she would avoid strenuous cognitive and emotion work, as well as potentially threatening or risky situations that often occurred in her paid work. Similarly, another interviewee who studied tribal communities as part of her anthropology degree told us that due to some of their culinary traditions and practices, she was not interested in visiting foreign countries like Africa or Asia. As she explained, 'there's no way I would even visit a country that puts guinea pigs on the menu. When I go on holiday I want it to be an enjoyable experience, not hardship.' The idea of being in 'vacation mode' was quite frequently framed as escapism from challenges – an uncomplicated, comfortable and enjoyable experience where ethical cosmopolitan skills are put aside and hedonist pleasure-centred objectives take over. Likewise, multicultural consumption was not framed as a means to facilitate visceral, reflexive and transformatory encounters with difference – nor did stories of consumption show signs of deeper aspirations to connect with that cultural group in question. Perhaps this is because it is difficult for pleasure and ethical openness to coexist given that ethical openness is commonly accompanied by vulnerabilities and anxieties.

Finally, we found that our interviewees' ethically cosmopolitan skills were at times challenged within work settings, where practices are governed by organisational principles and instrumentalist objectives. Although we had initially assumed transcultural workers to be inclined towards a generalised ethical cosmopolitan practice, the professional obligation to Otherness often does not necessarily afford universal ethical cosmopolitan practice as it is presented less as a matter of personal choice and instead managed by reference to values, learning and procedures external to oneself and often rooted in professional logics. The implications of the professional discourse, like the others we have analysed, are varyingly cosmopolitan and parochial. For example, when asked what makes people get along despite their differences, a community worker in her fifties replied: 'I suppose if you're in employment, you've got no choice really.' In relation to this response, we agree with Hannerz (1990) that an important criterion for delineating genuinely cosmopolitan practices of openness is if decisions are made by choice rather than force or necessity. Said differently, and according to Hoy (2005: 185), 'obligations that are enforced would, by virtue of the force behind them, not be freely undertaken and would not be in the realm of the ethical'. In another case, and demonstrating the self-interested nature of certain seemingly ethical openness practices, one woman explained that she specialised in indigenous health because dialysis nurses have more favourable

working hours and indigenous people frequently require dialysis treatments. When we asked if she felt 'passionate about indigenous health', she replied by giving multiple depersonalised accounts of how to deal with cultural diversities professionally to serve her function as a nurse. Indeed, when asked to rate how open she feels towards culturally diverse groups, she was inclined to take a parochial standpoint, and responded from a largely professional perspective:

Interviewee: I rate myself down because I look from a professional perspective. If I have a CV come across my desk the first thing I'll look at is their nationality. So then I'm probably not as open.

Facilitator: It's not a personal judgement, but professional judgement, or ... ?

Interviewee: I think it's a bit of both. You make your decisions based on how you expect that person to be based on how other people of that nationality have performed. I guess there wouldn't be particularly many friends that we have that are of other nationalities. Maybe if we were more open we would have more. I look at my mother in law, she takes in overseas students, has them come into her house and she develops those real relationships. I would rate her higher.

For this woman, cosmopolitan openness performed at work was not ethically underpinned, at least in how it was reported to us. Instead, professional values of work efficiency and patient safety seemed potentially to be in conflict with values of ethical cosmopolitan openness. Indeed, she goes on to suggest that having people of different cultures at work could be a safety issue, questioning whether it is in fact possible to integrate overseas trained healthcare staff 'into a fully functioning quality patient care focused organisation'. Clearly, then, she located her duty to public health broadly, and not specifically to multiculturalism or an ethics of openness. Based on findings such as this, we argue that professional life within culturally heterogeneous workplaces demands a wide array of conflicting neoliberal, self-interested, and more ethical forms of cosmopolitan practice.

Concluding discussion

The concept of cosmopolitanism has become an umbrella term which groups the archetypal cosmopolitan – the selfless global citizen motivated by principles of fairness and egalitarianism – with various transnational business people, frequent travellers, cosmocrats, omnivore consumers, cultural elites and aficionados. We have argued that although these groups are associated by virtue of their apparent shared receptiveness to cultural difference and their ability to be mobile, we also suggest a crucial distinction between them. While ethical cosmopolitan practice involves a mutual entanglement between cultures that challenges hierarchies, status cleavages and cultural privilege, the 'new' cosmopolitanisms – which tend to be self-interested and pleasure-oriented – maintain cultural hierarchies. Indeed, through a process of cognitive compartmentalisation, those who profit from globalisation are able to consume or otherwise utilise objects, experiences and cultural codes from the broader foreign culture with no deeper attachment to

humanitarian principles or even respect for the Other (Calcutt et al., 2009). Therefore, while much contemporary research is focused on the 'new' cosmopolitanisms, we suggest a clarification of the difference, and a heightened research focus on the form and character of everyday forms of ethical cosmopolitanism.

To explore ethical cosmopolitanism, its ontology, status and limits, we drew a sample of Australians who have chosen occupations that, on the face of it, require a high degree of cultural sensitivity, competence and intercultural engagements, and who we therefore expected to be good archetypes of ethical cosmopolitanism. Analysing these interview narratives, we found that our interviewees' discursive framings of cultural difference reflect cognitive processes of constructing perceptions of sameness, Otherness, purity and pollution to manage symbolic boundaries and borders between self and Other. We explained in this article that assigning positive value to difference can be considered the core of ethical cosmopolitan as it calls into question the validity of categories of purity and pollution: a 'binary structure that, alongside qualities that define civility and solidarity, identifies the polluted qualities that disable groups and individuals from participating in civil life' (Alexander, 2013: 537–538). In some situations, ethical cosmopolitanism is practised through a visceral-based cognitive scheme and language of categorisation where the Others' symbolic status as either pure or polluted is provoked by the work of perceptions and emotional registers in understanding difference, often associated with proximity to 'face' (Levinas, 1991). In other cases, ethical cosmopolitanism is facilitated through the use of a knowledge-based cognitive schema, where seemingly unprejudiced information is pieced together to determine the Others' value in an apparently more objective fashion. Both work together in relational tension, rather than being discrete categories. However, as has been suggested in past empirical research (Lamont and Aksartova, 2002) as well as by our interview data, socio-economic status appears to influence people's access to repertoires for doing ethical cosmopolitanism. More specifically, our findings indicate that lower status individuals have more frequent social contact and shared experiences with cultural and ethnic diversities, influencing them to draw more frequently on the visceral schema and competencies. People from a more privileged socio-economic background and often not frequently in contact with cultural and ethnic Others will tend to deal with diversity in a more abstract and intellectual fashion, drawing primarily on knowledge-based schemas. As mentioned, gender may be another core variable determining people's use of these two schemas, with women likely to draw more heavily on visceral schemas. And, although our sample inhibits us from exploring this matter in the current article, it is indeed the core topic of some existing research (Høy-Petersen et al., 2016).

Based on these findings, the article suggests an operational definition of ethical cosmopolitanism as a capacity to suspend parochialism; to be aware of the culturally constructed arbitrariness of boundaries and borders, and using cognitive and emotional strategies, to reconfigure one's reactions to and practices towards Otherness. Said differently, ethical cosmopolitanism exists as a type of technology of self constituted by a particular ethical dynamic based on mastery and suspense of one's interpersonal judgement; a capacity to rationalise and negate negative responses to difference that may arise in certain settings, or alternatively succumb to positive visceral responses to Otherness that challenge parochial knowledge and reasoning. Notably, the cultural and boundary

politics of inclusion and exclusion (Alexander, 2013; Douglas, 2003 [1966]; Seidman, 2013) has not before been utilised to systematically and empirically pin down everyday ethical cosmopolitan action.

We assumed our interviewees' transcultural and humanitarian helping work to indicate ethical cosmopolitan sensibilities. However, our analysis shows that pure forms of cosmopolitan ethics are rare. Indeed, we recognise that forms of ethical cosmopolitan often contains the discursive properties of the anti-cosmopolitan. As we identified in our interview data, social actors engage in constant reinterpretations of socially pre-interpreted knowledge of symbolic boundaries and borders, involving alternate phases of relaxing or reinforcing cognitive boundaries; being open to diversity in ways which overcome culturally entrenched categories and hierarchies in some situations, and close boundaries and borders in other situations. We found that ethically cosmopolitan cognitive work is often, but not always, suspended in professional work settings where pure and ethical openness must often give way to requirements to conform to organisational norms and principles. And, as this seemingly ethical transcultural helping work is externally enforced, and often framed as a necessity or a duty rather than a choice, it cannot necessarily be considered a reflexive form of cosmopolitanism (Hannerz, 1990). Our interviewees were not ethical cosmopolitan 'archetypes' immune to feeling culturally established boundaries and borders, nor able to properly and permanently neutralise judgements of the Other. This points to the compartmentalisation of cosmopolitan practices and their coexistence with what Beck (2002) once identified as cosmopolitanism's enemies. Rather than being one simple thing nameable as 'ethical cosmopolitan', we find people shift schemes of reasoning, switch from being closed to open, tolerant to intolerant, altruistic to calculating, and so on. In the context of our sample ethical cosmopolitan practices are not performed consistently, and we can speculate that this might also be the case at least among more widely those who are not professionally devoted to purifying their ethical practice.

Lastly, we would like to suggest one important reason for this instability of ethical cosmopolitan practice. In the literature, it seems as though the globalisation process – which is associated diversely with risk, a higher need for self-protection, possibilities for capital accumulation and self-interested pleasure – partly threatens deep and ethical forms of cosmopolitan openness as it requires people to follow objectives that are potentially the 'enemies' of ethical cosmopolitanism. Drawing upon a combination of cognitive schemas that facilitate openness and parochialism enables us to fulfil diverse human needs in the context of global living; to protect ourselves, or alternatively discover and learn new things, build deep and meaningful visceral connections with strangers, develop the necessary knowledge and skill to insert oneself successfully into multicultural settings, and also transcend the experience of ordinary life through the exotic. Our findings show that the practice of ethical cosmopolitanism may paradoxically produce un-cosmopolitan anxieties: as ethical cosmopolitanism is done by relaxing the borders of self to engage in a potentially reformatory mutual entanglement with cultural strangers, it commonly produces feelings of vulnerability, insecurity and fear. As such, ethical openness is practised in tension with people's instinct of self-protection. For this reason, ethical cosmopolitanism was delineated by our interviewees as hard work, and can be equated to a form of emotional labour (Hochschild, 2012). On the basis of this analysis, we have

developed the argument that ethical cosmopolitanism is done, and its limits navigated, through setting-contingent processes of using visceral and knowledge-based categories of sameness and difference, purity and danger; and by playing different schemas of judgement against one another in ways that deploy parochial, ethical or superficial forms of cosmopolitan practice.

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Résumé

Cet article propose une étude empirique sur les types et les limites des variantes éthiques de l'ouverture cosmopolite à partir d'une analyse d'entretiens approfondis auprès d'un échantillon

de professionnels et de volontaires ($N = 20$) dans des milieux professionnels culturellement hétérogènes qui se caractérisent par des interactions interpersonnelles exigeant des compétences interculturelles. Nous analysons la façon dont les gens assouplissent et durcissent les limites de l'ouverture sur les personnes, les objets et les pratiques qu'ils considèrent étrangères et différentes. Dans le contexte de deux dispositions initiales pour délibérer sur les principes et les schémas qui conduisent à agir en étant prêt à apprécier la différence, il ressort que les personnes interrogées ont recours à des catégorisations de l'altérité et de la similarité flexibles et changeantes en fonction du contexte, qui répondent à des priorités apparemment contradictoires concernant l'ouverture éthique, l'autoprotection, l'instrumentalisme et le repli sur soi. En étudiant les schémas associés à ces formes de compréhension éthique quotidienne, nos résultats montrent que leurs pratiques éthiques cosmopolites sont performatives et contextuelles, mêlées à divers schémas d'évaluation et de jugement potentiellement contradictoires.

Mots-clés

Cosmopolitisme, cosmopolitisme éthique, diversité culturelle, schémas cognitifs

Resumen

Este artículo explora empíricamente los tipos y los límites de las variantes éticas de apertura cosmopolita mediante el análisis de entrevistas en profundidad con una muestra de profesionales y voluntarios ($N = 20$) en lugares de trabajo culturalmente heterogéneos que se caracterizan por interacciones interpersonales que requieren competencias interculturales. Analizamos la forma en que las personas relajan y endurecen las barreras de la apertura hacia personas, objetos y prácticas que consideran poco familiares y diferentes. Dentro del contexto de dos esquemas primarios para deliberar los principios y esquemas para actuar de forma abierta a la valoración de la diferencia, encontramos que nuestros entrevistados usan categorizaciones flexibles y contextuales de otredad y mismidad que aparentemente responden a principios contradictorios sobre apertura ética, autoprotección, instrumentalismo y parroquialismo. Explorando los esquemas asociados con estas formas de entendimiento ético cotidiano, nuestros resultados muestran que su práctica ética cosmopolita es performativa y contextual, amalgamada con una variedad de esquemas de evaluación y juicio potencialmente conflictivos.

Palabras clave

Cosmopolitanismo, cosmopolitanismo ético, diversidad cultural, esquemas cognitivos